

Are You Prepared?

Short Story

It's 2:47 a.m. You're pulled from a deep sleep by a sound you can't quite place. You lie still, heart pounding, ears straining. Then you hear it again—glass breaking downstairs. Footsteps. Someone is in your house.

In that moment, everything changes. Your mind races through options. Do you have something to defend yourself with? Where are your loved ones? What's the plan? You realize in an instant that you're either prepared for this moment—or you're not.

Here's the uncomfortable truth: there are threats that don't announce themselves with breaking glass. They slip in quietly—through influence, desire, distraction—and by the time you realize what's happening, the damage is already done.

Opening Question

If someone were breaking into your house late at night, what is the first thing you would reach for—and why?

Follow-Up Question

Why do we instinctively feel the need to arm and protect ourselves when we sense danger? What does that tell us about how we're wired?

Scripture Passage

John 10:7-10 (NIV)

Therefore Jesus said again, "I tell you the truth, I am the gate for the sheep. All who ever came before me were thieves and robbers, but the sheep did not listen to them. I am the gate; whoever enters through me will be saved. He will come in and go out, and find pasture. The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy; I have come that they may have life, and have it to the full."

Discussion Questions

1. Jesus identifies Himself as "the gate" and warns about "the thief." What does the thief come to do, and how does this contrast with what Jesus offers? (See verse 10)
2. The "thief" can take many forms. In Luke 12:1, Jesus warns: "Be on your guard against the yeast of the Pharisees, which is hypocrisy." In 1 Timothy 6:10, Paul writes

that "the love of money is a root of all kinds of evil." How do misleading authorities and material pursuits function as thieves in our lives?

3. In 1 Peter 4:1-2, Peter writes: "Arm yourselves also with the same attitude... he does not live the rest of his earthly life for evil human desires, but rather for the will of God." What does it look like to "arm yourself" spiritually? How do we stay prepared for threats we can't always see coming?

Conclusion

The enemy doesn't always break down the door. Often, he operates through deception—appearing as authority, wealth, or pleasure—but his goal is always the same: to steal, kill, and destroy. Jesus came to give us life to the full. The question is whether we're prepared to recognize the thief's tactics and choose the abundant life offered through Christ.

Next Step

This week, identify one area where the "thief" may be quietly at work in your life—whether through misleading influences, material pursuit, or unhealthy desires. Bring it to God in prayer and ask for the wisdom and vigilance to choose life.